

COMPLEX TENSE FORMS

- **WHAT IS THE MEANING OF TENSE**

Tense is the form of the verb used to indicate the time of the action, the continuance of the action or the completeness of the action.

- ★ **COMPLEX TENSES**

Complex tenses are referring to sentences that have more than one verb (main and auxiliary verb) in them.

- ★ **THE USE OF AUXILIARY TO MAKE COMPLEX TENSE FORM**

To recognize the complex tense form in English, the students should know the examples of main verbs and auxiliary verbs we have and the formation of tenses.

The primary auxiliary verb

- ◇ **Verb To be :** am, is, are, was, were, be, being, been.
- ◇ **Verb To have :** has, have, had
- ◇ **Verb To do :** does, do, did.

The modal auxiliary verb are:

can, could, may, might, shall, should, will, would, must, ought to,

Types of COMPLEX TENSE FORMS

1. Present continuous tense

This indicates that an action is still on at the time of speaking or writing. A primary auxiliary verb (to be) is used with the ing form of the main verb. **Formation** – Subject + to be + verb-ing.

They are sleeping.

2. PRESENT PERFECT TENSE

This shows that an action which started and was completed in the past still has a link with the present. In this case, the auxiliary verb has or have are used with the past participle form of the main verb.

Formation – **Subject + has/have + past participle.**

The man has left for Abuja.

I have eaten the mango.

3. PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS TENSE

This expresses an action that began in the past and it still continue. In this case, the auxiliary verb have/has + to be (been)+verb +ing . **Formation** – Subject + have + been + verb -ing.

I have been teaching for nine years.

4. PAST CONTINUOUS TENSE

This is used to express an action that was going on in the past, at a particular time. It is also used to express an action that was going on in the past and interrupted by another action. In this case the auxiliary verb to be (was/were) + verb + ing + adverbial. **Formation** – Subject + was + verb -ing + adverbial.

I was teaching when the Principal sent for me.

5. PAST PERFECT TENSE

This is used to indicate that two or more actions took place in the past but one happened or was completed before the other(s). In this case, the auxiliary verb had + past participle of verb to be is used.

Formation – Subject + had + past participle + adverbial.

The boy had died before help reached him.

6. PAST PERFECT CONTINUOUS TENSE

This is used to show that an action had been completed at a particular time in the past that is under discussion or analysis now. To form this, we will use auxiliary verb had + to be (been) + verb + ing (verb present ing)

Formation – Subject + had + been + verb -ing + adverbial.

We had been praying since 1997 before God intervened in 2002.

7. FUTURE TENSE

This is used to show or indicate an action that will be performed in the future. To form this, we use auxiliary to be + verb + ing (verb present) **Formation – Subject + am + go + ing.**

I am going to church.

8. FUTURE PERFECT TENSE

This is used to say that something will have been completed or finished, by a certain time in the future. To form this, we use auxiliary verb will have + verb (past participle)

Formation: Subject + will/shall + have + verb + ed .

We will have graduated from college in five years.

9. FUTURE PERFECT CONTINUOUS TENSE

This is used to show that an action has been completed or taking place at that particular time. To form this, we use auxiliary will/shall + have + been + verb (to be used ing i.e present)

Formation – Subject + shall + have + been + verb (ing/en) + adverbial.

The men will have been eating by now.

IDENTIFICATION OF COMPLEX TENSE FORM.

In order to identify the different complex tense form where ever you meet them in use (sentences) you have to study their formation properly, know the types and numbers of auxiliary verb and the main verb (whether present, past or past participle) that were used in the formation of the sentences.

Examples: She/He comes to school everyday. You/We/They come to school everyday.

When you take a look at these sentences, you will notice that they contain only the main verb come (s). This shows that the sentences are simple tense form.

2. I am coming – present continuous tense (to be +verb+ing) the sentence above is in a complex tense form. It comprises of two auxiliary verb and the main verb.
3. I have been coming – present perfect continuous tense (have +to be +verb +ing)
4. By Sunday, he will have been feeding their goats for three days (shall + have + been + verb to be + verb + ing) – future perfect continuous tense.

USING THEM CORRECTLY IN SENTENCES.

1. They are sleeping early – present continuous tense
2. They have slept early – present perfect tense
3. She was phoning them – past continuous tense
4. She had phoned them – past perfect tense
5. They have been sleeping early – present perfect continuous tense
6. She had been trying to phone them before they arrived – present perfect continuous tense
7. She will buy a new house next year – future tense
8. She will be speaking at the meeting tonight – future continuous tense.
9. She will have ended the speech by 10pm – future perfect tense.

10. By 10pm, she will have been speaking for two hours – future perfect continuous tense.

ASSIGNMENT

Use the sentence below to form these complex tenses.

I do my homework.

1. Present Continuous Tense — I am doing my homework.

N/B – Number 1 has already been done for you.

2. Present Perfect Continuous Tense —
3. Past Perfect Tense —
4. Past Perfect Continuous Tense —
5. Future Tense —
6. Future Continuous Tense —
7. Future Perfect Tense —
8. Future Perfect Continuous Tense —